

The Hong Kong Polytechnic University

Subject Description Form

Please read the notes at the end of the table carefully before completing the form.

Subject Code	ENGL1BN04
Subject Title	Language and Society in Europe
Credit Value	3
Level	1
Pre-requisite / Co-requisite/ Exclusion	None
Cluster Area	Please check the box(es) below to indicate the cluster area(s) the subject contributes in a major way: ☐ Human Nature, Relations and Development ☒ Community, Organization and Globalisation ☐ History, Cultures and World Views ☐ Science, Technology and Environment
Requirements intended to fulfil	☐ China-Study Requirement (CSR) - More than 60% CSR-related content ☒ Eligible for “English Writing” (EW) designation - include an extensive piece of writing (1,500 - 2,500 words) AND “English Reading” (ER) designation - include a reading of an extensive text (100,000 words or 200 pages) ☐ Eligible for “Chinese Writing” (CW) designation - include an extensive piece of writing (2,000 – 3,000 characters) AND “Chinese Reading” (CR) designation - include a reading of an extensive text (100,000 characters or 200 pages) ☐ Others _____
Medium of Instruction	Please check the appropriate box: ☒ English ☐ Cantonese ☐ Putonghua ☐ Others (Please specify: _____)
Objectives	The subject is designed to: 1. develop and detail students’ awareness of the diverse identities and cultures found in Europe; 2. expand students’ comparative cultural understanding of the languages and cultures of selected European countries 3. extend students’ critical reading skills through a variety of reading assignments selected from a range of academic and non-academic texts; 4. enhance students’ ability to apply academic theories to analysing peoples, societies and events in Europe 5. cultivate students’ comparative cultural appreciation of the issues, events involved in historical, media and cultural events in this region

Intended Learning Outcomes (Note 1)	Upon completion of the subject, students will be able to: (a) demonstrate an understanding of the relations between languages and societies (b) appreciate and culturally compare identities and societies, as seen in the language, literature and media of selected European countries with which Hong Kong and mainland China have commercial relations; (c) understand a variety of academic theoretical approaches to analysing languages and societies (d) apply these analytically to a diverse range of cultural texts and events in Europe (e) develop their ability to appreciate, as well as reflect on, the linguistic and social issues and the cultural interest of selected European societies with which Hong Kong and mainland China interact commercially The learning outcomes stated above relate to the three essential features of GUR subjects as follows: (a) Literacy: this subject requires extensive reading and writing assignments. The material indicated for discussion includes academic texts but also semiotic artifacts such as media texts and movies in which images, editing, and soundtrack, offer a broad, multisemiotic approach to literacy. Students are required to understand and interpret a variety of texts (verbal and visual) produced in different contexts. (b) Higher order thinking: Students will be exposed to a variety of texts produced and consumed in different contexts about and from Europe, and will be expected to establish relations and interpret events from different popular, national and theoretical perspectives such as linguistics, literature, cinema, music, the media and history. Students should be able to identify and analyse several ways in which language and media interact in representing events, peoples, social realities. (c) Skills for life-long learning: Understanding and interpreting social and cultural events is a life-long learning skill which can be applied in all professional areas. The tools for cultural literacy this subject teaches will remain useful when students encounter, and must read other identities and social realities they encounter, and as Hong Kong and mainland China extend their global interactions over the next century. Skills include - sensitivity to the dialectical character of the social and linguistic components of identities - capacity to gain formal academic, historical and literary cultural content of a different society - ability to apply critical and theoretical approaches to similar content - awareness and appreciation of the informal content of culture especially as expressed in media and cinema
Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus (Note 2)	This subject offers students both a cultural appreciation and a critical understanding of the relation between language, identity and society in Europe. It focuses on cultural, media and historical texts from several European countries with which Hong Kong and mainland China have commercial relations. Consideration is given to tensions between different forces competing for influence in areas like politics, the environment, the media and economics, areas where language and culture are both a site and a means of dispute. The following topics will be covered:

	• Languages in Europe (reading multisemiotic texts) • Identities and societies in Europe (cross-cultural issues, academic perspectives on identity and culture) • Theoretical approaches to defining Europe (the European Union) • Governance (academic theories of community) • Cities and demography (existing communities) • Issues concerning European societies: migration, environment, trade, productivity • Popular culture (food, music, art) • The legacy of colonialism • Each week one of these topics will be explored from the particular point of view of one or two countries.						
Teaching/Learning Methodology (Note 3)	Interactive lectures that include online quizzes; seminars and group discussions; reading assignments; analysis of texts.						
Assessment Methods in Alignment with Intended Learning Outcomes (Note 4)	Specific assessment methods/tasks	% weighting	Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)				
			a	b	c	d	e
	1. Portfolio: Preparation for final assignment	40%	x	x	x	x	x
	2. Final paper	40%	x	x	x	x	x
	3. In-class online quizzes	20%	x		x		
	Total	100 %					
Note 1: Students will be asked to produce at least 4 pieces of work through the semester all leading to the final paper. These short pieces of work will be a combination of written summaries of selected texts; evaluation pieces; and/or a presentation (time dependent). These short assignments will be designed to teach students how to write an academic assignment by focusing on a different section of a full assignment. Students will be required to refer back to each short piece of work and to the feedback provided, when producing the next assignment. Note 2: the student will write a final paper, based on a list of 25 or 30 suggested topics. Students must use a theoretical perspective covered in class and apply it to a historical, media, film or cultural text treated in the class. Students with their own interests and ideas can discuss these with the teacher and have them approved. Note 3: The assessment criteria is based on: • Mastery of the topic (knowledge of the content) – outcomes (a), (c) • Critical thinking abilities – outcomes (b), (d), (e) and Skills for life-long learning requirements and Higher order thinking. • Writing capabilities – Literacy requirements.							
Student Study Effort Expected	Class contact:						
	▪ Lecture ▪ Seminar		26 Hrs. 13 Hrs.				
	Other student study effort:						

	▪ Preparation for seminars and lectures ▪ Preparation for assignments	28 Hrs. 52 Hrs.
	Total student study effort	119 Hrs.
Reading List and References	This subject should have an ER and an EW designation. Required Readings In addition to these readings, students will be also required to read at least four texts (articles/chapters/books) relevant to their selected assignment 2 topic. These will vary from topic to topic and year to year to ensure the information is current. House, J. (2011). English as a threat to other European languages and European multilingualism. <i>The languages and linguistics of Europe: A comprehensive guide</i>. Berlin: de Gruyter, 591-604. Marshall, T. (2015). Western Europe. In <i>Prisoners of geography: ten maps that explain everything about the world (Chapter 1)</i>. New York: Simon & Schuster. McDaniel, E. R., Samovar, L. A., & Porter, R. E. (2009). Understanding intercultural communication: The working principles. In L.A. Samovar, R.E. Porter, E.R. McDaniel, & C.S. Roy (Eds.), <i>Intercultural communication: A reader</i> (pp. 6-17). Boston: Cengage Learning. Wright, S. (2011). Language and nation building in Europe. In B. Kortmann, & J. van der Auwera (Eds.), <i>The languages and linguistics of Europe: a comprehensive guide</i>. (pp. 775-790). Berlin: Walter de Gruyter. Recommended Films In addition to the films indicated below other European films will be screened during the semester. These films will be selected from those offered by the various Consulates and the EU office so they will change every year. Becker, W. (Director). (2003). <i>Good Bye, Lenin!</i> [Motion picture]. Germany: Sony Pictures Classics. De Chauveron, P. (Director). (2014). <i>Qu'est-ce qu'on a fait au Bon Dieu? [Serial (bad) weddings]</i> [Motion picture]. France: UGC. Dion, C., & Laurent, M. (Directors). (2015). <i>Demain [Tomorrow]</i> [Motion picture]. France: Mars Distribution. Dizdar, J. (Director). (1999). <i>Beautiful People</i> [Motion picture]. United Kingdom: Channel Four Films. Jordan, N. (Director). (1996). <i>Michael Collins</i> [Motion picture]. United States: Warner Bros. Klapisch, C. (Director). (2002). <i>L'Auberge Espagnole [The Spanish Apartment]</i> [Motion picture]. France, Spain: Filmax International. Moore, J. (Director). (2001). <i>Behind enemy lines</i> [Motion picture]. United States: 20th Century Fox. Sheridan, J. (Producer). (1997). <i>The boxer</i> [Motion picture]. Ireland: Universal Studios. Tanović, D. (Director). (2002). <i>No Man's Land</i> [Motion picture]. Bosnia and Herzegovina, France, Slovenia, Italy, United Kingdom, Belgium: United Artists. Winterbottom, M. (Director). (1997). <i>Welcome to Sarajevo</i> [Motion picture]. United Kingdom: Miramax.	

	Zvyagintsev, A. (Director). (2014). <i>Leviathan</i> [Motion picture]. Russia: Sony Pictures Classics. Recommended Readings The list of recommended readings will vary each year to ensure that it includes current articles on the issues affecting Europe at the time of teaching.
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Revised by Renia Lopez, May 2018; Max Diaz, June 2024